



ROHIT SHARMA, THE TEST PLAYER, TOOK HIS TIME. THEN MADE IT COUNT

He dreamt of **whites as a boy** in Borivali. The journey was long, often lonely, but Rohit Sharma finally lived it on his own terms.

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“I understand that I haven’t done justice to my potential and abilities. It’s okay. I want to stay positive and keep looking forward to every challenge that lies ahead.” These words, spoken in October 2014 during an interview at the Cricket Club of India for *ESPNCricinfo* — my then employer — were Rohit Sharma’s response to a question about having played just seven Tests, despite having made his white-ball debut in 2007.

Despite being one of the all-time greats in limited-overs cricket, Rohit’s record in the whites has long been debated. Has he truly done justice to his talent in the Test arena? That question has followed him ever since his name first emerged on the maidans of Mumbai more than two

decades ago, when he was seen as a potential torchbearer of the city’s rich batting legacy.

His retirement from Test cricket earlier this month reignited that very debate among connoisseurs, critics and fans alike.

The writing had been on the wall since he sat out the deciding Test of the Border-Gavaskar Trophy in the New Year week. Perhaps age had caught up, evident in his movement. Or maybe he had gone too far trying to lead by example, pushing India’s batting approach in white-ball formats into red-ball territory.

In that sense, the last five months of his career mirrored the long wait he endured after his First-Class debut. Back then, the questions were “when will it happen?” Later, they became “why isn’t it happening?” and then “will it ever happen?” The doubts of 2025 weren’t very different from those between 2006 and 2013 — especially

from 2010 to 2013.

His Test career can be viewed in three distinct phases. The first was the frustrating wait for a debut, made more painful after he injured himself minutes before the toss in what would have been his first Test in Nagpur against South Africa in 2010. It would be three more years before he got his chance against the West Indies. During that phase, in various conversations — formal and informal — you could sense the weight of the “*mera number kab aayega*” (when will my turn come) mindset.

When the opportunity finally came, he made an instant impact with consecutive hundreds in his first two Tests. But the next five years saw him struggle to hold down a place. Injuries and India’s preference for five specialist bowlers meant Rohit was frequently in and out of the side. That stretch also saw him competing with his close friend